

Avinash Sable's national record in the 5,000m, clocking a time of 13:18.92 at the Portland Track Festival held last June. He improved that mark even further in September, clocking 13:11.82 at the Yogibo Athletics Challenge in Niigata.

Gulveer only had a few days of rest in Sirsa, spending time with little Pari, before he once again returned to racing — this time at the TCS Kolkata 25km race on 15th December, where he went on to set another Indian best time, finishing the race in 1:14.10.

The event finished, Gulveer has made his way back to the Sports Authority of India in Bengaluru, where he will look to build on an undoubtedly impressive year. With major competitions, including the Asian and World Championships, scheduled for next season, Gulveer, as India's standout long-distance runner, is expected to make his mark on the international stage. However, this push will bring its share of challenges for the new father.

"It's hard, for sure. The last time I was at home was for Diwali in 2023. Last year, I didn't go home because I had planned to compete and improve my records. Now I only got to spend a few days with my daughter. I don't think I'll get a chance to go home in 2025 or even until the end of 2026, after the Asian Games that year. The only time I will get to see Pari is over a video call on my phone. It's always at the back of my mind whether she'll recognise who I am," he wonders.

This isn't to say that Gulveer has any regrets about his career choice. In fact, sometimes he can scarcely believe how far he's come.

"If you had told me just a few years ago that I would be competing in Japan and the USA, and thinking of participating in competitions like the Asian Championships and World Championships, I wouldn't have believed you. I would barely have known what these events were," he says.

Late start

It's not as though Gulveer had no knowledge of the sport while

growing up. For youngsters in Sirsa, as in many villages in this region of western Uttar Pradesh, joining the army is a coveted vocation. Like many others, Gulveer ran on dirt tracks between the fields of chicory and mustard to prepare for the army recruitment tests. In 2018, he joined the 23 Grenadiers unit of the Indian Army as a *sipahi* (junior-most rank).

He fulfilled his military duties, serving in the mountains of the Galwan Valley in Ladakh and later in Arunachal Pradesh along the border with China. It was during his stint in Arunachal Pradesh — in his second year of service — that Gulveer first thought of pursuing a career as an athlete, inspired by the inter-unit cross-country race.

"It's important for everyone to take part, and there are many incentives if you do well. I learned that if you're a good athlete, you can train specifically as a runner. That interested me. Army life is very tough, especially with guard duty. So, I was very interested in doing well in that race. I remember that was the first time I properly prepared for a race," he says.

Gulveer won his first cross-country race, and his performance was impressive



Right guidance: Gulveer's first cross-country win caught the eye of Younus Khan, coach of the long-distance running programme at the Army Sports Institute in Pune.

SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

enough to catch the eye of Younus Khan, coach of the long-distance running programme at the Army Sports Institute in Pune. "Someone called me from Arunachal Pradesh and said there was this really talented runner. He ran the 10km cross-country race in 30:58. That was very impressive, especially for someone who didn't have much experience in running," says Khan.

That same year, Khan brought Gulveer to Pune, where the youngster would finally receive formal coaching. In 2021, Gulveer won another inter-unit race and was ready to move onto track running. Khan says he wasn't surprised by Gulveer's progress.

"He was very disciplined. I'd never see him miss a day of training. And he was really talented. Every day, you could see in the workouts that he was getting stronger," says Khan.

While his coaches had high hopes for him even then, Gulveer's own goals were fairly modest — a